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THA 131: Basic Theatre Design and Crafts - Scenery, Lighting and Models

From a director's idea to a buildable, budgeted design

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Design is a set of constraints solved creatively: text, space, budget, labour and safety. This pack covers design elements and principles, ground plans and models, materials and construction basics, lighting and sound roles, and how to present a design to a production team.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Apply the elements and principles of design to a script's requirements.
- Produce a ground plan and a scale model for a short scene.
- Identify common scenery, lighting and sound equipment and their functions.
- Present a design with a budget and a build schedule.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Elements and principles

Design language is learnable and assessable.

- Elements: line, shape, form, colour, texture and space.
- Principles: contrast, rhythm, unity, emphasis, pattern, movement, balance and scale.
- Start from the text: period, location, tone, entrances and required levels.
- Design for the audience's sightlines, not for a photograph.
- Every element should be justified by the production concept.
- A design that cannot be built within budget and time is not finished.

Drawings, models and materials

Technical communication prevents expensive mistakes.

- Ground plan: viewed from above, to scale, with all entrances and furniture positions.
- Elevation and section: show heights and construction.
- Model: white card or foam board at 1:25 or 1:50, with a human figure for scale.
- Timber, plywood, canvas, steel and fabric each impose different construction rules.
- Paint and finish affect how lighting reads on stage.
- Label everything and include a materials list.

> **Safety is part of design**
> A platform that flexes, a rail that wobbles or a cable across a walkway is a failed design regardless of how it looks.

Lighting, sound and presentation

Design is a collaborative department, not a solo artwork.

- Lighting shapes visibility, focus, mood and time of day.
- Common units: profile and fresnel lanterns, LED fixtures, dimmers and a control desk.
- Colour temperature and gels change how costume and paint read.
- Sound design covers reinforcement, effects and cues; know the difference between live and recorded sources.
- Present the concept, ground plan, model, materials list and budget on one board.
- Walk the production team through the design in five minutes without reading from notes.

From script to ground plan

A designer reads a script for spatial demands, not for adjectives. Underline every entrance and exit, every level change, every object a character uses, and every line that fixes a location. That list is the brief. A design that ignores an exit will be redrawn during the build, which is expensive and embarrassing.

The ground plan is the first tool: a scale drawing of the stage seen from above, showing the set footprint, furniture positions, entrances and the auditorium edge. It is drawn at a stated scale, usually 1:25 or 1:50, and every element is labelled. The director uses it to block; the builder uses it to cut; the lighting designer uses it to place positions.

Elevations and sections come next, showing heights and construction. A section drawing is what reveals a problem the plan hides: a platform that blocks sightlines from the side seats, or a doorway too narrow for a costume to pass through.

Lighting, sound and the design team